OTC vs. Prescription Hearing Aids: What Tennessee Patients Need to Know

Over-the-counter (OTC) hearing aids have made improved hearing more accessible than ever. You can walk into a pharmacy or simply click “add to cart” and have a device in your hands pretty quickly. For adults who are just starting to notice changes with their hearing, that kind of convenience can feel like a perfect solution.

But hearing loss isn’t always safe to treat on your own. In some cases, hearing loss is actually a sign of a deeper medical issue. An OTC device might be effective at making things louder, but it won’t diagnose or treat the underlying cause.

As your trusted audiology team at Inman Audiology here in Troy, our priority is your long-term hearing and brain health. So, we want to give you some tips to help you decide whether OTC hearing aids are appropriate for you, or whether you should skip them entirely.

The Basic Differences Between Prescription and OTC

OTC hearing aids and prescription hearing aids are both regulated by the FDA, but they are designed for very different situations.

OTC hearing aids are meant for adults who believe they have mild to moderate hearing loss. They’re self-fit, self-adjusted, and sold without a hearing test. They can work for those who want an entry-level device and feel confident they don’t have any medical complications.

Prescription hearing aids are medical devices programmed by a licensed audiologist based on a full diagnostic evaluation. They can treat any level of hearing loss, from mild to profound, and they’re appropriate for patients of all ages… including infants! They come with professional fitting, ear mapping, and tuning to make sure the device matches your exact hearing needs.

You can think of it this way: over-the-counter hearing aids are “one-size-fits-most.” Prescription hearing aids are “custom-built-for-you.”

The FDA “Medical Red Flags” You Should Not Ignore

As you decide whether OTC hearing aids are right for you, it's a good idea to check the FDA's guidance first. If you experience any of the following, they recommend that you bypass OTC devices completely and see an audiologist or Ear, Nose, and Throat (ENT) physician right away:

- Fluid, pus, or blood draining from your ear in the past 6 months.
- Rapid onset hearing loss (for example, you woke up and couldn't hear)
- Hearing loss that is noticeably worse in just one ear
- Ringing, roaring, or buzzing (tinnitus) in just one ear
- Chronic dizziness or severe vertigo
- Pain or physical discomfort in the ear
- A visible deformity of the ear
- A sensation that your ear is completely plugged with earwax or a foreign object

These symptoms are not "normal hearing loss." They are signs of a medical condition that requires a professional evaluation. In fact, putting an OTC hearing aid into an ear that's experiencing one of these issues may make the condition harder to resolve.

To be clear, there is nothing intrinsically bad or dangerous about OTC hearing aids. The danger comes from using them to mask a medical problem instead of identifying it.

A Professional Hearing Test Should Always Come First

Even if you feel confident that your hearing loss is mild, guessing your hearing level is extremely difficult. Most people underestimate how much hearing they've actually lost, or they assume both ears are affected equally when they're not.

A diagnostic hearing test at Inman Audiology is quick, painless, and gives you a precise picture of what's happening. You'll learn:

- Your exact hearing thresholds for several different frequencies
- Whether your hearing loss is occurring in the middle or inner ear
- Whether your hearing loss is equal in both ears
- Whether a medical referral is needed
- How your brain processes the information your ears sends to it
- Whether OTC hearing aids are appropriate

And here's something else to consider: sometimes you don't need hearing aids at all. You may simply need professional earwax removal or treatment for a temporary condition!

We Can Help You Navigate Your Options

OTC hearing aids can be a great option for the right patient, but they are not a substitute for professional evaluation, especially when any of the above “red flags” are present. If you’re noticing signs of hearing loss, let’s start with the safest step: a baseline hearing evaluation.

Call us at 615-622-0153 to schedule your hearing test.